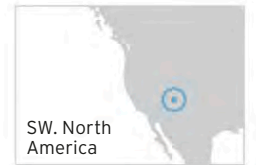


Cliff Palace

A palace of 150 rooms built by the Ancestral Puebloans into the side of a steep and inaccessible cliff



While some Puebloan towns lay on open ground, many more were built into the sides of steep cliffs. Such protected locations were easily defensible, suggesting that they were built at times of increasing competition among local tribes for scarce resources.

Primeval palace

The most impressive of these dwellings is Cliff Palace, found in a canyon in the Mesa Verde plateau of southwest Colorado. Built between 1190 and 1260, it was mainly constructed of sandstone blocks and wooden beams held together with a mortar of soil, ash, and water.

The Palace contains around 150 rooms and 23 sunken *kivas* (see opposite); the high number of *kivas* suggests that Cliff Palace was the center of a widespread local community. However, the site was abandoned by 1300, probably in response to extreme drought.

▼ PALACE RUINS

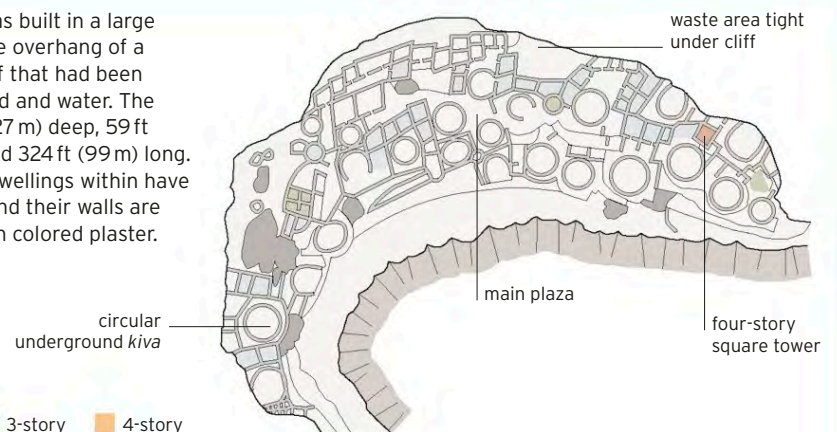
In Cliff Palace, the cramped buildings rise up above each other on terraces, many of them excavated to produce subterranean *kivas*.

CAVE PROTECTION

Cliff Palace was built in a large cave under the overhang of a sandstone cliff that had been eroded by wind and water. The cave is 89 ft (27 m) deep, 59 ft (18 m) high, and 324 ft (99 m) long. Some of the dwellings within have four stories, and their walls are decorated with colored plaster.

KEY

■ 2-story ■ 3-story ■ 4-story



Cliff Palace was **rediscovered** in **1888** by **ranchers** searching for their **cattle**

